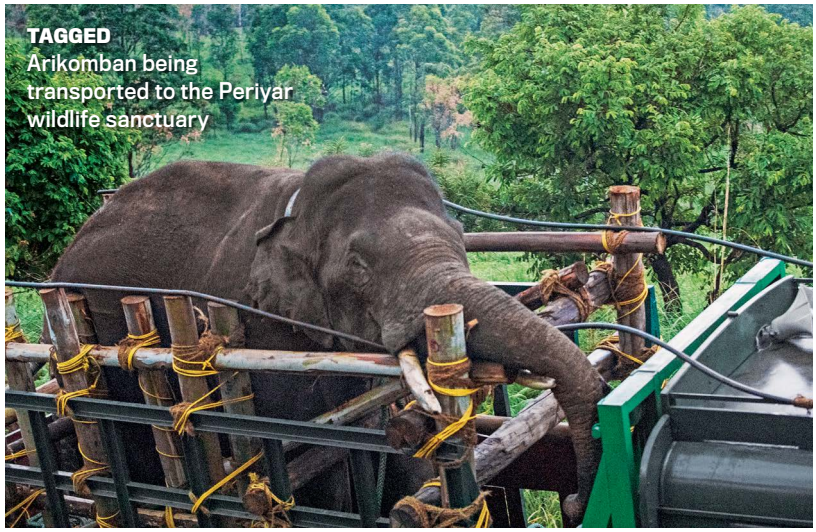


TAGGED
Arikomban being transported to the Periyar wildlife sanctuary

AFP

KERALA/ ROGUE ELEPHANT

A JUMBO-SIZED PROBLEM

By Jeemon Jacob

In a dramatic, 13-hour operation on April 29, a rogue elephant that had terrorised the Chinnakanal area of Kerala's Idukki district for close to 20 years was finally captured and transported to the Periyar Tiger Reserve. A 35-year-old wild male tusker with an unnatural fondness for rice grains—hence the name 'Arikomban' (literally: Rice Tusker)—it had gained notoriety for its targeted raids on human habitation. Ration shops, with their stocks of PDS rice and other edibles, were a particular favourite. Over the years, it had also killed 18 people and destroyed 100-odd houses.

Local politicians had been under considerable public pressure to put the fetters on Arikomban. Finally, when the government acquiesced in March to capturing it, animal lovers approached the Kerala High Court against the move to keep the tusker in captivity and got an interim stay issued on March 23. The court then directed the state forest department to find a new habitat for Arikomban. An expert panel suggested the Parambikulam Tiger Reserve, in a continuous swathe stretching to the Silent Valley national park. Local protests, including from Nenmara MLA K. Babu, stalled the move, and the Supreme Court refused to interfere. Finally, the high court endorsed the forest department's plan to relocate the elephant to the Periyar reserve, some 100 km away.

The operation area in Chinnakanal was duly cordoned off and a prohibition order issued. "Operation Arikomban was challenging and risky due to the terrain and the presence of other wild tuskers," chief veterinary surgeon Dr Arun Zachariah, who headed the operation, told INDIA TODAY. A 150-member task force sweated it out before the jumbo was tranquilised, fixed with a satellite GPS-VHF collar, shifted to a truck with the help of four *kumkis* (trained elephants used to subdue wild ones), transported to Periyar and released in the Mullakudy zone.

THE ROGUE JUMBO'S TRANSLOCATION WAS A SUCCESS. BUT NOW HE HAS WANDERED INTO TAMIL NADU, GIVING THE FOREST DEPT THERE A JOLT

The GPS signals showed Arikomban tracing a trail to the Meghamalai forest area in Tamil Nadu, some 40 km from where he was released. There are worries that it might return to Chinnakanal—relocated wild tuskers have been known to return to their home range after traversing hundreds of miles—but wildlife experts say it is unlikely. "Periyar has plenty of attractions for Arikomban: thick vegetation, sumptuous water and a large number of female elephants. It may take 2-3 months for it to adapt to the new habitat. Also, the lack of forest cover between Periyar and Chinnakanal will be a deterrent factor," says Dr E.K. Easwaran, former chief forest veterinary surgeon. A report submitted to the HC after the mission says Arikomban is also partially blind in the right eye and has injured the lower part of his trunk. "The wounds were treated and the elephant was found fit to be released," it states.

Meanwhile, news coming in suggests the tusker is giving sleepless nights to the Tamil Nadu forest department now. Alerts were issued after it raided a banana plantation and destroyed a department jeep. A 120-member rapid task force is monitoring its movements. Tamil Nadu has banned tourists in the area till further orders.

Since 2023 dawned, Arikomban has off and on been in the news in Kerala—constantly so for the past 2-3 weeks, with even global news outlets like the BBC covering 'Operation Arikomban'. And now there are reports that Badusha Cinemas, a leading production company, has announced a movie on him. A teaser poster released on May 6 featured a female elephant with a cub. The story apparently revolves around Arikomban losing his mother when he was just two years old, becoming the notorious rogue, and ending with the translocation mission where he walks off into the jungle, finally at peace. The real-life Arikomban's story doesn't seem to be taking a similar trajectory. Not yet, at least. ■